EPILOGUE

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On 19 September 2017 Nobel Peace Prize laureate and democratically elected leader of Myanmar, Aung San Suu Kyi finally bowed to pressure from the international community and addressed perhaps the biggest political development in her country's post-independence history. At the time of writing, the Myanmar military's crackdown on the Rohingya Muslim ethnic group has displaced some 580,000 people, or well over a third of the entire Rohingya population, and driven them across the border into Bangladesh.

Ms Suu Kyi's speech was not what the international community would have expected from a Nobel Peace Prize winner. Her first stated priority was to 'find out why this is happening'. This was odd because in late 2016 she commissioned an enquiry into the Rohingya 'problem' after decades of their being persecuted. This enquiry was led by the globally respected diplomat Kofi Annan, the former UN Secretary-General, and had already produced a full analysis and a list of recommendations a month prior to Ms Suu Kyi's speech.

Then Ms Suu Kyi bemoaned the fact that this violence was ongoing 'despite all [her government's] efforts'. Another odd thing to say, given that her government had taken no measures to alleviate the Rohingya situation in Rakhine state since the earlier violence in 2016. Moreover it should be reiterated that the current violence is being carried out by Myanmar's army.

Next, she claimed that there had been 'no clearing operations since 5 September' by the army in Rakhine state, even as Western journalists based in Bangladesh reported seeing fresh fires in villages across the border in Myanmar. To assure her audience that there had not been sustained violence against the Rohingyas, she argued that more than 50 per cent of Muslim villages remained intact.